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Influencer marketing: brand control, commercial orientation and post credibility

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ABSTRACT

Leveraging social media influencers allows companies to provide information on their products in a more social and interactive way. Yet, scholarly research on the implications of the effect of influencers on consumer trust, their interest and the purchase decision process is still in its infancy. This study proposes a theoretical model to explain how perceived brand control over an influencer's post and the perceived commercial orientation of such a post affects consumer trust in influencers. Results show that trust of the influencer is reduced more by the post's perceived commercial orientation than perceived brand control of the influencer's post. Although perceived brand control also reduces the willingness to search for more information. The results also show that trust of the influencer is salient in predicting post credibility, which in turn predicts interest and willingness to search for more information.

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Introduction

The use of influencers has given rise to so-called 'influencer marketing'. Among the innovative marketing strategies, influencer marketing emerges as the most cost-effective, as well as the most direct and organic when contacting with potential customers (Lou et al., 2019). Influencer marketing seeks to create favourable WOM (word of mouth) by employing social media users with the ability to influence the behaviour of their large numbers of followers (Petrescu et al., 2018). Influencers are seen as personal and credible sources that the consumer can relate to (Boerman, 2020; De Veirman et al., 2017), in addition to their messages having a digital format (Evans et al., 2017). Companies have realised the potential of working with influencers (Pöyry et al., 2019); firms can reduce brand-related perceived risk and increase brand awareness (Chatterjee, 2011), while at the same time providing their audiences with valuable information (Pang et al., 2016). The followers or fans of influencers are increasingly placing their trust in messages shared by their peers when searching for information and deciding which products/services to buy

(Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017; Lou & Yuan, 2019; Pöyry et al., 2019) and so the trust and independence of influencers is paramount. The importance of influencers depends not only on the number of followers they have but also on the suitability of influencers for the brand mentioned in their post, in terms of experience, congruence with the brand and credibility, and the strength of their relationship with their followers (e.g. Arora et al., 2019; Reinikainen et al., 2020; De Veirman et al., 2017). Paradoxically, the strength of influencers comes from them not being associated with sponsors, but it is this strength that organisations wish to leverage in the marketplace (Boerman, 2020; Evans et al., 2017). It seems there is a dance of seduction between marketers, influencers and their social networks. On the one hand, it involves perceived independence, the credibility of influencers and their affiliation to an issue or brand, and on the other, the need for influencer posts to be in step with the brand and commercial outcomes of the social media marketer (see Boerman, 2020; Pöyry et al., 2019).

The use of influencers as brand ambassadors, creating sponsored content with the company (Boerman, 2020), has led to an increase in investment in this strategy. It is expected that 63% of companies will increase their budget in influencer marketing during 2020 (The Influencer Marketing Hub, 2020), this following a rise of 59% the previous year (Rakuten Marketing, 2019). This tendency could value the influencer marketing industry at an estimated 15 billion dollars in 2022, having started at 8 billion dollars in 2019 (BusinessInsider, 2019). In terms of return on investment, companies get 5 dollars back for every dollar invested (The Influencer Marketing Hub, 2020). Also, 80% of marketers consider influencer marketing-related actions to be effective, and 89% point out that ROI is comparable with, or even better than, other marketing actions (Mediakix, 2019). Furthermore, 69.4% of influencers recognise that they are profit-oriented (TapInfluence & Altimeter, 2019). Thus, with many companies aiming to enhance their competitive edge thanks to the use of influencer programmes (Brown & Hayes, 2008; Trivedi & Sama, 2020), there is a need to understand not only the influencer campaigns, but what to avoid with an increasingly jaded and sceptical follower base (Lin et al., 2017; Petrescu et al., 2018). Brands and influencers need to negotiate with great care the content to be created and shared, maintaining quality criteria but at the same time being able to deliver positive commercial effects for the brand without losing the authenticity and credibility of the message and sender (Gannon & Prothero, 2018; Pöyry et al., 2019; Stubb et al., 2019).

This study aims to examine the effects that both perceived brand control and the commercial orientation of the influencer's message have on trust in the influencer and the credibility of his/her message. Previous studies have shown that the disclosure of a commercial purpose when sharing content negatively affects credibility (see Evans et al., 2017; De Veirman et al., 2017), but they have not approached the effects of perceived brand control and commercial orientation on trust in the influencer and credibility of his/her message. In turn, although the effects of the credibility of the influencer's message on attitudes and buying intentions have been analysed (see Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017; Lou & Yuan, 2019; Xiao et al., 2018), the effects on pre-purchase aspects, such as interest in the message that might stimulate consumers to start a product-related search process, have been ignored.

The remainder of this paper is structured as follows: firstly, it presents a background and the proposed model and its hypotheses, explaining the creation of trust in the influencer and of a post's credibility, as well as their effects on followers' attention.

Subsequently, it describes the methodology followed in the study and its results. Lastly, the conclusion includes a discussion of the theoretical and practical implications, the study's limitations, and some future research suggestions.

Background

Main research topics on influencer marketing

As far back as 2008, Brown and Hayes described influencers as being similar to consumers who have a direct impact on their followers' behaviours. De Veirman et al. (2017, p. 1) define them as 'people who built a large network of followers, and are considered as trusted tastemakers in one or several niches'. In this way, they are content generators, with the status of experts who have created a network of followers that they influence through valuable content on social media (Ge & Gretzel, 2018; Lou & Yuan, 2019), and are considered as a credible source of information (Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017; Schouten et al., 2019).

The literature on influencer marketing has studied various topics on the subject; a summary of topics, related papers, main findings and research opportunities found in relevant influencer marketing literature is provided in [Appendix 2](#). A first group of works has focused on identifying aspects of influencer suitability. Indexes have been proposed to find niches of influencers by using variables such as engagement (shares, comments, etc.), number of posts, footprints, etc. (see Arora et al., 2019). Similarly, De Veirman et al. (2017) employed variables such as the number of followers, the number of influencer follows, cooperation with other influencers, etc., in order to establish the highest rate of likeability of each influencer, as well as their effects on the consumer. On the other hand, there is a group of works focused on niche themes, such as the effects of influencer marketing on the strategic decision and communication process of companies are studied (Enke & Borchers, 2019); the use of influencer marketing as a favourable environment for the generation of Communities of Practice (Gannon & Prothero, 2018); the use of emerging languages and changes in communication standards (Ge & Gretzel, 2018); the creation of tribes between influencers and followers (Mardon et al., 2018); or the role of the audience in the success of an influencer marketing strategy (Reinikainen et al., 2020).

A third research group focuses on a sponsorship disclosure. Boerman (2020) verified that disclosure affects the recognition of the commercial intention of the message, negatively affecting brand recall and engagement with posts. Similarly, Evans et al. (2017) studied the effects of disclosure on ad recognition, influencing attitude towards the brand and the intention to share the message. Stubb et al. (2019) studied the influencer's strategy of trying to justify the production of sponsored content, called 'compensation justification disclosure'. Its results highlight that this strategy positively affects consumer attitudes, increasing the credibility of the message.

The broadest group of works analyzes how positive attitudes and behaviours are generated in the consumer from influencer marketing actions. In this sense, Lou et al. (2019) have confirmed that higher levels of engagement and consumer sentiments are obtained in influencer-promoted messages than in brand-promoted ads. Similarly, Schouten et al. (2019) have shown that the consumer trusts and identifies more with an influencer than with a celebrity endorser, improving the effectiveness of the message.

Along the same lines, Trivedi and Sama (2020) have compared celebrity vs. expert influencers, using variables such as brand admiration and brand attitude and their effects on purchase intentions. Pöyry et al. (2019) observed the effect that the authenticity and attractiveness of the influencer has on buying attitudes and intentions. On the other hand, the study by Shan et al. (2019) shows that the congruence between influencer and brand, and parasocial identification, affect attitude towards the brand, engagement and purchase intentions.

An important strand of research has examined consumer trust and the credibility of influencers and their messages. For example, Djafarova and Rushworth (2017) investigated the impact of Instagram on source credibility, consumer buying intention and social identification. On Twitter, Jin and Phua (2014) studied how the number of followers affected source credibility and WOM. Jin et al. (2019) have recently shown that consumers rely more on messages issued by Instagram influencers than on traditional celebrities, with a more positive attitude towards the brand. On the other hand, Lou and Yuan (2019) verified that confidence in the post of an influencer increases due to the value of the content, its attractiveness and the similarity to its followers. The work of Sokolova and Kefi (2020) shows that the parasocial interaction of the audience and credibility have a positive influence on purchase intention. Finally, Xiao et al. (2018) studied the positive effect that informational cues have on the credibility assessments of content created by influencers on YouTube.

Research gap

The novelty of the study of influencer marketing means that there is still no consolidated theoretical body or a widely accepted definition (Enke & Borchers, 2019). Although companies are gradually abandoning traditional celebrity endorsements in favour of social media influencers (Schouten et al., 2019), influencer marketing literature is scarce and based on previous endorsement theory (e.g. Lou & Yuan, 2019; Reinikainen et al., 2020; Shan et al., 2019). The development of influencer marketing's own literature (e.g. Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017; De Veirman et al., 2017) has yet to produce the extensive knowledge of the key mechanisms required to make it effective (Lou & Yuan, 2019; Schouten et al., 2019), and to understand its effects on the consumer (Shan et al., 2019). Understanding these mechanisms is fundamental. The right choice of influencers and the correct management of their content can show the effects on the emotional relationships with consumers (Trivedi & Sama, 2020), and might have other benefits for the brand, like better attitudes towards it or purchase intentions (Evans et al., 2017). At the same time, influencers themselves would ideally need to know the effects of their posts in order to adapt content and make it more persuasive (Sokolova & Kefi, 2020). In this sense, the credibility of the message issued and the confidence in the influencer are considered key variables in the success of influencer marketing actions (Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017; Jin & Phua, 2014; De Veirman et al., 2017). It is these aspects that our study considers. In particular, we focus on six perceptual variables present in every influencer marketing campaign: two exogenous constructs (perceived brand control over the influencer's post and the post's perceived commercial orientation) in the proposed model, presented in the next section, and four endogenous variables (trust in the influencer, post/message credibility, interest of the post's content, and willingness to search for more information about

the post's products/services). Both influencers and brands need to take them into account when designing or assessing such a programme.

Hypotheses development

Trust in the influencer

Many theoretical studies on celebrity endorsement focus on trust in the celebrity conveying the message (Jiang et al., 2015). Trust, in the context of celebrity endorsement, can be defined as the degree to which a message's audience perceives the sender (celebrity) as being able to convey a sense of integrity, honesty and credibility by means of a marketing medium (Tripp et al., 1994; Wang et al., 2017). Trust in the celebrity has been shown to be linked to a more positive attitude towards the sponsored message (Wang et al., 2017). The use of social media has increased the use of celebrity endorsement, as it can be dealt with in a more natural and believable way than in other media (Boerman, 2020). This is why literature indicates that there is more trust in influencers than in other figures (Kiss & Bichler, 2008), since they are, in many ways, similar to their followers (Uzunoglu & Kip, 2014) and are regarded as authentic (Petrescu et al., 2018) and accessible (De Veirman et al., 2017).

The web '2.0' social media context also allows consumers to control their own search for information and purchasing experiences, creating and sharing information and content on products and brands (Wu et al., 2015). This has led some companies to lose control over their brand's image (Booth & Matic, 2011; Copulsky & Saia, 2016), creating a problem for many brands unprepared for this (Vernuccio & Ceccotti, 2015). Accordingly, brands may attempt to manage the online conversations taking place about their products (Patterson et al., 2008) through the use of influencers, leveraging their greater credibility. Influencers are perceived as independent (Freberg et al., 2011) and their messages are considered genuine and not manipulated by the brand (Evans et al., 2017; Jin & Phua, 2014). However, in many cases, the company provides the content or message to be shared, indicating hashtags, timing, keywords, etc. (Copulsky & Saia, 2016), so that the original content does not actually come from the influencer. The main reason for this is to control both the information conveyed by the influencer regarding the brand and to prevent possible crises in its image (Jiang et al., 2015).

Existing literature on the control of content on brands on the Internet recommends that companies participate in conversations as equals with other members of the brand community (Fournier & Avery, 2011; Gensler et al., 2013), ceding some control to the consumer (Bal et al., 2017). Also, increasing brand control of the content shared by influencers may end up creating a feeling among consumers that the information is biased and inauthentic (Woods, 2016). This would give rise to negative attitudes towards the issuer of the message, in this case, the influencer (Hwang & Jeong, 2016), with the public losing trust in him or her. Thus, it is necessary to preserve the balance between control and creativity and the freedom of the influencer (Sokolova & Kefi, 2020). This gives rise to our first research hypothesis:

H1: The brand/sponsor's control over the content of the influencer's post is negatively related to the trust that followers will have in the influencer.

Content is one of the key aspects in the relationship between brands and followers (Rosenthal & Brito, 2017). This is why influencers can act as important players in the creation of information on brands (Lou & Yuan, 2019; Stubb et al., 2019). Many companies have paid to obtain positive reviews on online review sites (Lee & Koo, 2012). They also pay for influencers to create content favourable to the company or to share other content created directly by the brand (Chatterjee, 2011). But this creates doubt in the mind of the consumer as to the trustworthiness of the influencer's opinion, not to mention their impartiality (Stubb et al., 2019); giving rise to scepticism (Boerman et al., 2017). Consumers, therefore, want influencers to make recommendations and share their real opinion about brands (Petrescu et al., 2018). This situation has led some countries to impose a legal obligation to disclose whether content is sponsored or not (Boerman et al., 2017; Hwang & Jeong, 2016). In other cases, some influencers, at their own initiative, affirm that their opinion is honest, even if the post is sponsored (Hwang & Jeong, 2016; Stubb et al., 2019). Even a public, but disingenuous, non-commercial orientation would lead consumers to purchase the recommended products more than if they perceived a commercial intent (Boerman et al., 2017; Sammis et al., 2016; Shan et al., 2019).

Existing literature demonstrates the desire of influencers to create and share commercial posts in exchange for consideration, even if, in such cases, consumers display negative attitudes towards this content (Chatterjee, 2011; Petrescu et al., 2018) due to the reduced credibility of the celebrity sharing them (Boerman, 2020; Hwang & Jeong, 2016). Therefore, the commercial purpose behind content shared by the influencer has a negative effect on consumers' perceptions of the influencer (Petrescu et al., 2018; Uribe et al., 2016), reducing his or her credibility and trust (Hwang & Jeong, 2016). Therefore,

H2: The commercial orientation of the influencer's post is negatively related to the trust that followers will have in the influencer.

Post credibility

A message's credibility is defined as the extent to which consumers perceive an online source of information as being impartial, believable and factually based (Koo, 2016). Credibility relates to an individual assessment of the trustworthiness of its content (Appelman & Sundar, 2016). The characteristics of the source of information, the message and the recipients themselves have an impact upon this perception (Filieri, 2016). Therefore, if consumers do not regard a message as credible, they become resistant to attempts at persuasion (Lee & Koo, 2012).

One concept associated with the above and which can be used to analyse the objectivity and usefulness of the message is being balanced – that is if the message covers both the strengths and weaknesses of the product or brand discussed (Hwang & Jeong, 2016). These latter messages can be used to partially offset the effect of sponsorship disclosure (Hwang & Jeong, 2016) and are regarded as more credible than one-sided ones (Uribe et al., 2016). The fact that consumers believe the message to be authentic, and they can therefore regard it as credible, is important, as this affects the audience's attitudes and behaviour.

In this regard, the electronic word-of-mouth messages (eWOM) created in conversations, rather than seeded eWOM, based on peer recommendations, are regarded as being free of commercial intent and manipulation, and more trustworthy than others with commercial intent (Uzunoglu & Kip, 2014; De Veirman et al., 2017). Nevertheless, brands may attempt to control the messages issued by the endorsers and influencers they hire, to avoid certain risks or problems with the image they want to convey for the product. If consumers detect that this is taking place, they will perceive the message as being less authentic (Woods, 2016) and as including information biased in the company's interest (Uribe et al., 2016). This will obviously affect the message's credibility (Carl, 2008) and the way in which consumers react to it (Hwang & Jeong, 2016). Additionally, this will affect consumer opinion of all the messages issued by the influencer, impacting negatively on his or her own image and credibility (Woods, 2016). Thus,

H3: The brand/sponsor's control over the content of the influencer's post is negatively related to the follower's credibility in the post.

Similarly, any concealment of a commercial relationship between an influencer and a brand, established through sponsorship, may be difficult for consumers to detect. This may lead them to think that the influencer's or endorser's opinion is sincere and genuine, inciting greater acceptance of the latter's commercial intent (Boerman et al., 2017; Sammis et al., 2016). In any case, when a commercial intent is perceived, the credibility of both the influencer (Hwang & Jeong, 2016) and the message (Boerman, 2020) is affected. To keep followers from becoming sceptical and not accepting the message (Uribe et al., 2016), influencers declare that their opinion is honest (Hwang & Jeong, 2016; Stubb et al., 2019). This is because consumers have more trust in honest, proven messages with no (apparent) commercial intent (Jung et al., 2016; Koo, 2016), and in messages issued by influencers considered to have similar interests and no connection with the companies (De Veirman et al., 2017). When there is clear commercial intent, the messages become less useful (Petrescu et al., 2018), as their content is a worse fit with the audience's real interests (Zhang et al., 2017). To improve message acceptance and achieve higher levels of commitment and acceptance, the message must focus on brand-related information and opinions, not on encouraging sales (Boerman, 2020; Uribe et al., 2016). Therefore,

H4: The commercial orientation of the influencer's post is negatively related to the follower's credibility in the post.

Another issue to consider regarding credibility involves the role-played by the originator. The message's credibility is strongly influenced by the trust that the recipient places in the source of the information (Evans & Clark, 2012; Filieri, 2016), because communicator perceptions impact on the persuasion and perception of messages in audiences (Sokolova & Kefi, 2020). In this regard, information shared by other consumers who are influential on social media is regarded as independent and valid (Uzunoglu & Kip, 2014). Additionally, the information received by those with whom they are weakly linked with is regarded as less credible (Koo, 2016). Nevertheless, influencers *do* establish links with their followers, which would increase trust. This makes their information more credible

than that offered by other sources such as brands or celebrities (Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017). So, brands try to choose trusted influencers to enhance the credibility of the message sent through them (Enke & Borchers, 2019) and thereby ensure that the message is more effective due to being better accepted (Jin et al., 2019; Shan et al., 2019). In this sense, previous studies propose that trust in the influencer positively influences the confidence of his/her followers in their messages about brands (Lou & Yuan, 2019; Xiao et al., 2018). This leads to hypothesis 5:

H5: The follower's trust in the influencer is positively related to the follower's credibility in the post.

Interest of the post content

The content's interest is the degree to which someone regards the information as of interest to them, thus making them more willing to read it (Chen et al., 2014). This variable is closely linked to the relevance of the information and with other aspects such as fun and pleasure (see Chen et al., 2014). Influencers' messages offer content that attracts consumers' attention, giving rise to cognitive responses that lead to higher levels of persuasion (Chen et al., 2014). This turns them into engaging content that affects consumer behaviour, in terms of both purchasing processes and recommendations, appealing to either rational or emotional components (Chen et al., 2014; Wang et al., 2017).

Through social media, brands attempt to meet the challenge of keeping their followers interested in their content and engaged with their messages (Rosenthal & Brito, 2017). Consumers show a greater tendency to engage and interact with messages issued by influencers than by the brands themselves (Lou et al., 2019). This is due to the fact that influencers generate user-oriented content, based on their experience and honesty (Arora et al., 2019; Evans et al., 2017; Schouten et al., 2019), which makes messages more acceptable and interesting to consumers. Credible messages reduce consumers' resistance to such messages (Evans et al., 2017; De Veirman et al., 2017). In particular, the credibility of messages by other consumers (Cheung et al., 2009) and influencers (Lou & Yuan, 2019) has a significant impact on both their persuasive power and consumer attitudes (Xiao et al., 2018), establishing a relationship between perceived truthfulness in the message's fit and audience interest (Stubb et al., 2019; Zhang et al., 2017). Hence,

H6: The perceived credibility in the influencer's post among followers is positively related to their interest in the post's content.

Willingness to search for more information about the posted product

The use of influencers has a great effect on how information is disseminated and how behaviours and attitudes spread through social media (Enke & Borchers, 2019; Reinikainen et al., 2020; Shan et al., 2019). This is due to the way in which consumers are currently affected by information received via WOM, the most influential source of information (Roelens et al., 2016). This has led companies' use of WOM programmes based on other

consumers' recommendations to become commonplace on social media (Roelens et al., 2016). As such, consumers seek information received from other people through recommendations (Hajli et al., 2017).

The first thing that consumers do when facing a purchase process, online or not, is to seek out relevant information, processing it to help them spend less time on evaluating products of interest to them (Wu et al., 2015); they try to just consider accurate information (Petrescu et al., 2018). In this way, the purpose of the search for information is to give sense to things about which people are forming an opinion (Hajli et al., 2017). This process is affected not only by personal circumstances (e.g. experience) but also situational (e.g. purchasing context) and external ones; such as the information supplied by others (Utkarsh, 2017), which has been favoured by the large networks of consumers available in social media (Stubb et al., 2019). In the case of influencers, one of a company's objectives will be for consumers to embark upon a purchase decision-making process after receiving information from the influencer (Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017; Lou & Yuan, 2019; Pöyry et al., 2019), thereby bringing about a search for more information on the product. This information must also be consistent with that already in the consumer's possession, to enhance its acceptance by its recipients (Petrescu et al., 2018).

Consumers may exercise passive control over information, ignoring that which is uninteresting or irrelevant (Wu et al., 2015). Influencers and other opinion leaders, however, contact their public by means of suggestions regarded as being of interest to their audiences, encouraging followers to find out more information and, in the end, purchase the product (Flynn et al., 1996; Schouten et al., 2019). Thus, to start the purchase process by searching for more information, the content generated by the influencer must arouse the interest of the consumer (Lou & Yuan, 2019). So, posts need to be interesting for consumers to show behaviour that is more engaged with the brand (Lin et al., 2017) and to encourage them to find out more about the recommended products (Chen et al., 2014). Therefore, we propose one final hypothesis for our model:

H7: The followers' interest in the influencer's post content is positively related to their willingness to search for more information about the product/service mentioned in the post.

Figure 1 depicts the full model with the hypothesised relationships.

Methodology

Research methodology

This study is based on a survey by questionnaire to Instagram users.

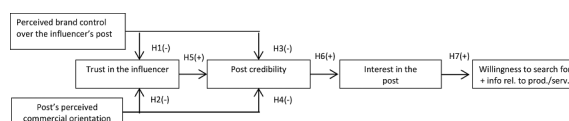


Figure 1. Conceptual model.

Sampling criteria and method

The survey was conducted in November and December 2017 following a non-probabilistic sampling method. Study participants had to be habitual social media network users – particularly Instagram – and women, in line with the women's beauty product featured in the post used in the study. It was not a prerequisite to be a follower of any influencers, although the subjects did have to be familiar with the kind of messages shared by them. In this regard, the percentage of respondents who followed influencers daily stood at 59.2%, with a great variety of different profiles, including both celebrities and micro-influencers, and encompassing a wide range of subjects (beauty, sports, fitness, humour, music, film, etc.).

Questionnaire: measures and pre-test

The questionnaire was drawn up on the basis of the information shown in [Appendix 1](#), which shows the scales used to measure the model's constructs in detail. All the study's items were measured using 7-point rating scales.

Before the survey stage, we performed a pre-test with 20 female undergraduate students to appropriately adapt the questionnaire, making sure that it was understandable. The pre-test also helped in choosing the post that we would finally use for the study. The criteria for selecting the post were that there was a lack of prior knowledge of the influencer to avoid biasing the results if the respondent had a pre-established image of the individual, and that it involved a sector of which the sample's target public had knowledge, so they would regard it as normal that promotion was being carried out via this type of opinion leader. The post chosen was a simulation shared by a fictitious influencer (Ciara Bell, @ciarabellworld), specialised in sharing and creating beauty brand-related content. To guarantee the realism of the post's image, its picture was obtained from the profile of a real Instagrammer, a micro-influencer who is focused on this sector; her identity has been omitted here. Also, due to using a picture of a real influencer without permission to be published, such picture is not shown, although it was available during the review process.

Data collection and sample

Participants were recruited among university students, following the sampling criteria, at the business school at the University of Malaga (Spain). To increase the participation ratio, potential participants were told that respondents would be entered into a draw to receive 50 euros. The questionnaire was taken in person in a computer lab, using computers to show the post used in the study. The process was introduced and supervised by one of the researchers. This meant it was possible to guarantee the time needed to review the post, and to resolve any doubts that arose. Participants were asked to answer a questionnaire based on a post they viewed previously.

The total number of valid questionnaires was 503. Also, 91.1% of respondents stated that they were studying for a bachelor's degree, with ages ranging mainly between 20 and 23 (84.5%). Also, 89.3% were full-time students, while 10% combined their studies with work; 72.8% of the respondents had no income of their own and were supported by their families, 16.7% had an income lower than € 6,000 annually, and only 10.5% earned more than € 6,000 annually. As for the social networks that they used most when

following influencers, Facebook and Instagram were in first place (82.5% and 81.7% respectively), followed by YouTube (48.7%) and Twitter (21.3%).

Results

Measurement model

Partial Least Squares (PLS) path modelling was used to simultaneously estimate both the measurement and structural components of the model. PLS is a component-based structural equation modelling technique that has advantages over covariance modelling (Slotegraaf & Dickinson, 2004). There are many precedents for the use of PLS in recent marketing studies (Anderson & Swaminathan, 2011; Hair et al., 2012; Hennig-Thurau et al., 2007). PLS is a variance-based technique, which can deal well with issues of formative versus reflective measures and moderation effects and can include categorical variables. PLS is not constrained by identification issues, even in complex models (Hair et al., 2012). Maximisation of variance explained (or R^2 values) in all dependent variables is the primary objective of PLS (Hulland, 1999).

Measurement model details are shown in Table 1, and the structural model was analysed using PLS software Warp PLS 6.0 (Knock, 2017). This model simultaneously estimates the parameters of the structural model and the psychometric properties of the measurement model and provides detailed information about both the direct and indirect path relationships between the variables considered. Measures for this study were developed by procedures as recommended by Gefen and Straub (2005), where all standardised factor loadings onto constructs had to be greater than 0.70 and have significant t-values. All measures met the cut-off of 0.50 on the average variance extracted (AVE) as recommended by Fornell and Larcker (1981); Cronbach Alpha reliabilities were above the recommended point of 0.70.

To confirm that the different latent variables extracted a higher share of variance from their own indicators than from other latent variables, we tested for discriminant validity among the various constructs. The square root of the average variance extracted (AVE) by each of the latent variables as shown in the diagonal of Table 2 is higher than the correlation between the latent variable and all the other latent variables, which provided evidence of discriminant validity (Fornell & Larcker, 1981). A further examination of the cross-loadings of items also confirmed that there was evidence of convergent validity. This was shown by all items loading highly onto their respective constructs, but not cross-loading onto other constructs, with most cross-loading being around 0.1 to 0.2. In addition, we tested for collinearity between the variables. All variables exhibited a variance inflation factor (VIF) of between 2.66 (Trust of the Influencers) and 1.38 (Brand control of the post) with an average VIF of 1.30. These measures are well within the suggested acceptable range of 3.3 or lower for evidence of multicollinearity and common bias method (Kock & Lynn, 2012). Once the measurement model was satisfactory (Hock et al., 2010), we proceeded to evaluate the structural model.

Table 1. Details of the measures used in this study.

Variables	Measurement statistics		
	Std. Factor Loading	Weight	Mean (SD)
Scale and items: weights (w) and loadings (L) of latent constructs			
Brand control (3 items, Cronbach $\alpha = 0.79$, AVE = 0.71).			
The brand/sponsor of the posted product/service supervises the content created by the influencer.	0.83	0.39	4.89 (1.67)
The information that the influencer wishes to share with his/her followers must first be filtered by the brand/sponsor of the posted product/service.	0.83	0.39	4.54 (1.74)
The brand/sponsor of the posted product/service controls the flows of information and content between the influencer and his/her followers.	0.87	0.36	4.43 (1.77)
Post commercial orientation (5 items, Cronbach $\alpha = 0.92$, AVE = 0.69).			
The post shared by the influencer tries to sell rather than to inform.	0.83	0.24	4.95 (1.70)
The post shared by the influencer applies pressure to get followers to buy the product/service.	0.71	0.21	3.96 (1.72)
The post shared by the influencer tries to convince followers to buy, not to satisfy his/her followers' need for information.	0.89	0.26	4.62 (1.68)
The post shared by the influencer is more focused on persuading followers to buy than on their true information interests.	0.90	0.26	4.69 (1.64)
The post shared by the influencer stretches the truth when describing a product/service.	0.81	0.24	4.52 (1.65)
Trust in the influencer (3 items, Cronbach $\alpha = 0.92$, AVE = 0.86).			
The influencer is trustworthy.	0.92	0.36	3.92 (1.25)
The influencer is honest.	0.92	0.37	3.70 (1.40)
The influencer is reliable.	0.94	0.36	3.75 (1.34)
Post credibility (3 items, Cronbach $\alpha = 0.92$, AVE = 0.86).			
Not reliable/reliable.	0.92	0.36	3.79 (1.44)
Not credible/credible.	0.94	0.36	3.72 (1.53)
Not believable/believable.	0.92	0.37	3.85 (1.41)
Interest of the post's content (3 items, Cronbach $\alpha = 0.95$; AVE = 0.88).			
I am interested in its content.	0.93	0.35	4.32 (1.50)
I like the post.	0.94	0.36	4.19 (1.52)
I have a good impression of the shared content.	0.92	0.36	4.20 (1.52)
Willingness to search for more information about the product in the post. (3 items, Cronbach $\alpha = 0.92$; AVE = 0.79).			
I think I will search for information about the posted product/service.	0.88	0.37	4.69 (1.64)
I think I will search for online word of mouth about the posted product/service.	0.90	0.38	4.87 (1.57)
I think I will compare prices of the posted product/service.	0.88	0.37	4.86 (1.59)

Note: S.D. = Standard Deviation; AVE = Average Variance Extracted.

Structural model

As shown in Figure 2, the results supported H1 (brand control of the post is negatively related to trust in the influencer, $\beta = 0.07$, $p < 0.05$), H2 (commercial orientation of the post is negatively related to trust in the influencer, $\beta = -0.50$, $p < 0.01$), H4 (commercial orientation of the post is negatively related to credibility of the post, $\beta = -0.12$,

Table 2. Correlations between constructs.

	BranCont	Trust_In	Cred_ps	Commer	Interes	Willing
BranCont	0.84	−0.30**	−0.20**	0.51**	−0.11*	−0.18**
Trust_In	−0.30**	0.93	0.72**	−0.54**	0.57**	0.48**
Cred_ps	−0.20**	0.72**	0.93	−0.46**	0.58**	0.39**
Commer	0.51**	−0.54**	−0.46**	0.83	−0.31**	−0.25**
Interes	−0.11*	0.57**	0.58**	−0.31**	0.94	0.52**
Willing	−0.18**	0.48**	0.39**	−0.25**	0.52**	0.89

Note: * = $p < 0.05$, ** = $p < 0.01$. Note: Square root of average variances extracted (AVEs) shown on diagonal in bold. BrandCont, Brand Control, Trust_In, Trust in the influencer, Cred_ps, Post credibility, Commer, Commercial orientation of the post, Interes, Interest in the post's content, Willing, Willingness to search for more information about the product in the post. N = 503

$p < 0.01$), H5 (trust in the influencer is positively related to credibility of the post, $\beta = 0.67$, $p < 0.01$), H6 (credibility of the post is positively related to interest of the post, $\beta = 0.59$, $p < 0.01$) and H7 (interest in the post is positively related to search for more information, $\beta = 0.51$, $p < 0.01$).

Support was not found for H3 (brand control of the post is negatively related to credibility of the post, $\beta = -0.06$, n.s), though the path is in the right sense. Overall the model explains quite well the credibility of the post ($R^2 = 0.55$), and to some extent the interest in the post ($R^2 = 0.35$) and does a reasonable job in explaining trust in the influencer and willingness to search for more information ($R^2 = 0.29$ for both). The goodness of fit index of the model (GOF), derived from prediction and measurement fit (Tenenhaus et al., 2005), was 0.54, which was greater than the acceptable large fit of the model to the data of 0.36.

General discussion

This study contributes to research on mechanisms that lead to successful influencer marketing campaigns. Existing scholarship has indicated the benefits of using influencers, such as in purchase intentions, the persuasiveness of the message issued or improved attitudes towards the brand (see Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017; Lou & Yuan, 2019; Xiao et al., 2018). Other works have focused on the importance of trusting both influencers and their messages (e.g. Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017; Jin & Phua, 2014; De Veirman et al., 2017), or on the negative effects of disclosure and commercial intentions that could be related to influencer marketing (e.g. Shan et al., 2019; Sokolova & Kefi, 2020; Stubb et al., 2019). The study contributes to existing research by combining these lines of research, such that the relationships between the perception of commercial orientation in an influencer's message and trust in the source and the message can be approached as

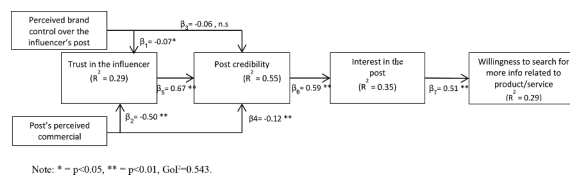


Figure 2. PLS path model. Note: * = $p < 0.05$, ** = $p < 0.01$, GoF = 0.543.

a whole, in the specific context of influencer marketing. It offers several insights into how consumers perceive an influencer's post, leading them to display certain responses towards companies (trust, interest in the message, start of purchase decision-making process, etc.), which allows us to establish an explanatory theoretical framework.

Theoretical implications

First, we emphasise the negative influence that the two variables proposed to measure the effects of disclosure on consumer perception (perceived brand control over the influencer's and post's perceived commercial orientation) have on trusting the source and his/her message used in actions of influencer marketing; in particular, a perceived commercial orientation of the message shows greater negative effects than those of perceived brand control. This shows that consumers penalise this kind of message, as they regard it as insincere, possibly due to the impression that the influencer is not acting in accordance with his or her beliefs but is instead prioritising economic profit over creating useful content for followers, thus giving rise to resistance to messages. These results are in line with other similar ones offered by the influencer marketing literature (e.g. Boerman, 2020; Boerman et al., 2017; Shan et al., 2019).

We also find evidence of a less negative relationship between a brand's control over an influencer and trust in the influencer and the message's credibility. This could be explained by consumers largely accepting the content shared by influencers, showing great trust in them and their criteria for deciding which brands to promote or not. So, they tolerate somewhat that the brand may have some control over their recommendations, but they presume that influencers will always act according to their convictions, and in accordance with their followers' interests. These results contradict those obtained by previous research in the field of endorsement and branding which indicate that the capacity to influence is lost and the message issuer's status is harmed due to a loss of trust in him or her and the credibility of his or her message (e.g. Evans et al., 2017; Jin & Phua, 2014). However, in recent works in the particular context of influencer marketing, it is observed that the audience does not judge it to be entirely negative that the influencer works with brands, as long as an opinion on the posted products is perceived to be genuine and sincere (see Boerman, 2020). The differing results in this social media context of influencers show that the links that followers establish with influencers are different from those established with celebrities in the traditional media, with them having a more favourable attitude and greater trust.

Additionally, our results point to the positive effect that having trust in influencers has on their messages. In other words, in the context of influencer marketing, when there is trust in an influencer, his or her messages have higher credibility levels. These results confirm those obtained by a number of authors (e.g. Borah, 2015; Carr & Hayes, 2014; Jung et al., 2016) in other fields, but also in influencer marketing (e.g. Lou & Yuan, 2019; Xiao et al., 2018), which establish that if a source is regarded as trustworthy based on the influencer's authority, neutrality or level of expertise, this trust embraces the messages that they issue.

Similarly, the results confirm that a message's credibility is a strong predictor, or even a prerequisite, for the interest it attracts. These results are in line with those obtained by a number of authors in the context of messages issued on social media (Chang et al., 2015; Dobelet et al., 2005), by endorsers (Dwivedi & Johnson, 2013) and in online reviews (Koo,

2016; Lee & Koo, 2012), indicating that a message's credibility gives rise to positive attitudes towards it, such as interest or engagement. It should also be considered that previous research has not focused so much on the interest value of the influencer's message than on its capacity to persuade (e.g. Xiao et al., 2018). But focusing on interest is more appropriate than persuasion, which is closer to traditional endorsement environments in which the commercial orientation is clearer, although in influencer marketing actions a balance is usually sought between providing an audience with interesting content and brands' commercial interests (see Stubb et al., 2019).

Lastly, the results confirm the relationship between interest in the message and the intention to seek more information on the product/brand appearing in the post. This relationship has not been the object of direct study in existing literature, although it has considered consumer attitudes towards the advertised brand and purchase intentions (e.g. Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017; Lou & Yuan, 2019; Pöyry et al., 2019; Schouten et al., 2019; Sokolova & Kefi, 2020). Therefore, this study contributes to the better understanding of the relationship between influencers and consumers' decision processes, particularly in the initial stage of information search where influencer marketing actions can have a greater effect.

In closing, the model highlights the importance of trust in both the influencer and his/her message, which causes consumers to be interested in the message and progress to embarking upon the purchase decision-making process, seeking information on the product. There is some negative impact on brand control, but crucially the message must be constructed so that there is no perception of a high degree of commercial orientation, as this would lead to a loss of trust in the influencer, who would appear to be acting against his/her audience's interests.

Managerial implications

This research offers a number of practical recommendations and indicates implications for marketing practitioners. What all these recommendations have in common is the fact that these practitioners need to overhaul the ways in which they engage in conversations about their brands with their customers. First, social media has created an environment that permits more interactive and direct communication with customers, shaping a more creative, informal relationship. Strategies used in social media actions must adapt to a context with new rules; consumers are more sceptical, being aware of the commercial purpose and the control behind shared product-related contents. Therefore, brands must adopt more mature and transparent standards; they should understand that the credibility of both influencers and messages comes first, before any commercial purpose.

Second, the feedback, scalability and interactivity of social media, means that the content they post can only be trusted if it is perceived to be free of commercial interests. A degree of brand control tempts fate somewhat, but the main issue is that managers need to yield control somewhat and avoid making 'every post a winner' in social media. On the other hand, it has meant that brands have lost a great deal of control over their messages, which are now, in part, created by the brand community on social media. Considering that influencers know their audience better, brands must allow them creative freedom in order to generate content of interest. It is thanks to this creativity that audiences follow influencers and believe their messages. Thus, the influencer should

identify what is of interest, and vouch for the brand's quality of content and good adjustment to the profile of its customers. To facilitate their role, and also to improve interaction with questions from the audience, brands must offer information to the influencer about their products, services, etc. Brands can provide influencers with guidelines on the objectives of the company, target audience, strategies followed in other media, etc., which will also help the influencer to decide whether to collaborate or not in an influencer campaign. The important thing is to help and guide the influencer, not control their content.

Third, working with an influencer who is not a natural fit for the brand generates non-credible messages, since followers might perceive that both are collaborating merely for commercial purposes. This implies forming relationships with influencers only when the collaboration is genuine (Lou & Yuan, 2019). For example, it would be appropriate to collaborate with influencers previously used by the brand, for whom consumers have already shown their sympathy. Likewise, influencers must strengthen their credibility by acting ethically, or they could lose followers' trust for not doing so. In order to avoid unethical perceptions in their audiences, influencers should disclose and justify their sponsorships.

Fourth, influencers know the content their audience wants. Interactions on social media generate more engagement through comments, likes or sharing content. With this in mind, the brand should pay less attention to the number of followers the influencer has, and more to the engagement achieved with the audience. Even sponsored posts can be perceived as highly valuable to consumers, as long as they provide information of interest to the audience. In this sense, when influencers offer content on products, their followers often initiate information search mechanisms. Thus, influencers might trigger the sales funnel, generating interest and brand awareness. Brands must facilitate this search, providing influencers with links that can be used in their shared content with followers. Likewise, influencers can establish their own sales channels, fully implemented on networks such as Instagram or Twitter. Finally, brands in social media, and perhaps in the offline world, may leverage the strong connections with followers established through influencers (Harrigan et al., 2018) because of the interest in credible content, but this content can easily be tainted by the advocacy of sponsors. In addition, brands and influencers should seek to create a long-term relationship, enabling influencers to act as brand ambassadors. Likewise, brands must monitor the performance of influencers to provide insight as to how consumers have understood their collaboration with influencers, what their perception has been and, eventually, whether they have engaged in any brand-related behaviour triggered by influencers.

Limitations and future research

No study is without limitations, and this one is no exception. Firstly, the sample used is not a probability sample and consisted of university students forming part of the 'millennial' generation. However, it should be noted that members of this generation are highly active social media users, that the entire sample knew of at least one influencer, with 59.2% of it following at least one daily, and that it has been used in other studies on influencer marketing and endorsement (e.g. McCormick, 2016; Uribe et al., 2016). The reliability of the results could be improved by using a random sample representative of all social media users, and also by not focusing on a single country (Spain).

Secondly, the choice of a single Instagram post (promoting a single product), although guaranteeing avoidance of any risk arising from the use of multiple stimuli, may affect the results obtained. So, future research could use several different posts and/or social media, establishing a comparison between the different samples, allowing for an analysis of whether differences arise depending upon the configuration of the post or the influencer used.

Lastly, future research could include other variables to broaden the scope of the proposed model. For example, the influencer's persuasive power (Langner et al., 2013) or their personality (Zamudio, 2016), the eWOM from followers (Boerman et al., 2017), prior attitudes towards the brand (Doyle et al., 2014), brand equity generated (Dwivedi & Johnson, 2013) or clearly specifying that the post is sponsored (Hwang & Jeong, 2016). Likewise, future research could consider the nexus of product adoption and consumer privacy and how that could potentially impact adoption (Miltgen et al., 2016).

To conclude, the dance between social media marketers, influencers and their followers can be a tango more than a waltz, with various parties wishing to show their independence and evoking the trust of others, despite having conflicting interests. Yet the dance can still be enjoyable to those who follow, providing the seduction of commerce is not overt, and the control of the movements is recognised to some extent but not overpowering.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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Appendices

Appendix 1. Measurement scales

These are the measurement scales applied to our model's constructs. In all cases, 7-point rating scales were used. In some cases, Likert-type scales (1 = totally disagree, 7 = totally agree) were used and in others differential semantic scales.

Brand's degree of control over the post. We used a 3-item scale validated by Martínez-López et al. (2017):

- The brand/sponsor of the posted product/service supervises the content created by the influencer.
- The information that the influencer wishes to share with his/her followers must first be filtered by the brand/sponsor of the posted product/service.
- The brand/sponsor of the posted product/service controls the flows of information and content between the influencer and his/her followers.

Post commercial orientation. We adapted the 5-item scale used by Boles et al. (2001) to measure selling orientation:

- The post shared by the influencer tries to sell rather than to inform.
- The post shared by the influencer applies pressure to get followers to buy the product/service.
- The post shared by the influencer tries to convince followers to buy, not to satisfy his/her followers' need for information.
- The post shared by the influencer is more focused on persuading followers to buy than on their true information interests.
- The post shared by the influencer stretches the truth when describing a product/service.

Trust in the influencer. We adapted a 3-item scale recently used by Dwivedi and Johnson (2013), and originally proposed by Ohanian (1990), to assess an endorser's trustworthiness. In our case we used 'influencer' instead of 'endorser':

- The influencer is trustworthy.
- The influencer is honest.
- The influencer is reliable.

Post credibility. The differential semantic scale used by Lim et al. (2015) was used to measure message credibility: *How reliable was the information of the influencer's post you watched?*

- Not reliable/reliable.
- Not credible/credible.
- Not believable/believable.

Interest of the post's content. A scale was adapted from the 3-item scale used by Wei and Lu (2013) to measure interest in a product in an ad: *After reading this influencer's post:*

- I am interested in its content.
- I like it.
- I have a good impression of the shared content.

Willingness to search for more information about the product in the post. We adapted the 3-item scale also used by Wei and Lu (2013) to measure an individual's intention to search for more information about a product in an ad:

- I think I will search for information about the posted product/service.
- I think I will search for online word of mouth about the posted product/service.
- I think I will compare prices of the posted product/service.

Appendix 2. Main topics, findings and research opportunities related to influencer marketing

Topics	Related papers	Main findings	Research opportunities
<i>Influencer suitability</i>	De Veirman et al. (2017).	Popularity of influencers on Instagram with many followers makes them more likeable and perceived as leaders, although they are not suitable for divergent products.	Evaluate the characteristics of the influencer, the credibility of the content and the engagement of their followers to see the real effects on the behaviour of their audience.
	Arora et al. (2019).	Preparation of an index to measure the adequacy of influencers in brand actions on different social networks. Impact on consumers mainly depends on engagement, outreach, sentiment, and growth.	Study the attributes related to the network to better understand the information-spreading process. Identify different personality types of influencers and their effects on their audiences.
<i>Niche themes</i>	Gannon and Prothero (2018).	Bloggers and beauty YouTubers create communities through User-Generated Content (UGC), developing the dimensions of mutual engagement, shared repertoires and joint enterprise.	Research different profiles of influencers (e.g. by gender), sectors and audiences.
	Ge and Gretzel (2018).	The use of emojis by influencers makes it possible to improve the communication and persuasive power of their messages, by achieving greater engagement as the communication is more emotional.	Examine consumers' responses to rhetorical messages used by influencers.
	Mardon et al. (2018).	YouTubers act as tribal entrepreneurs in the communities created with their audiences. In them, new forms of emotional labour are established, focused on the expression of self-awareness, other-praising moral and emotional censorship.	Study the emotions of the audience felt but not expressed in online public contexts. Analyse new emotional and ethical dynamics around marketing.
	Enke and Borchers (2019).	They establish definitions of social media influencers, considering them figures of interest in companies' communication strategies.	Investigate the strategic importance of influencers in brand strategies. Analyse the relationships and dynamics between influencer, organisations, representation agencies and interest groups.
	Reinikainen et al. (2020).	Parasocial interactions with the influencer increase the credibility of the influencer, which leads to trust in the brand and to an increase in purchase intentions. In these interactions, they moderate comments made by other users.	Explore different media and actions (e.g. Instagram Stories) and consider the interaction between influencer and other followers.
<i>Sponsorship disclosure</i>	Carpenter Childers et al. (2019).	Influencer marketing strategies are still unknown territory for companies, and are key to studying the plans and capabilities of communication agencies when using them.	Analyse the transformation processes from traditional endorsement to influencer marketing, balancing the message control processes regarding the authenticity and credibility of the influencer.
	Evans et al. (2017).	The disclosure of sponsorship increases the recognition of the advertisement by the audience, negatively influencing both how attitudes towards the message are generated and the intentions to share it.	Study the differences in behaviour in different types of audiences, brands, influencers, media and disclosures. Investigate how to mitigate the negative effects of disclosure.

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Topics	Retaled papers	Main findings	Research opportunities
<i>Positive attitudes and behaviours</i>	Stubb et al. (2019).	Justification of brand sponsorship of the message improves consumer attitudes towards the influencer, the credibility of the source and the message, compared to a sponsorship disclosure without explanation.	Learn about the mechanisms behind sponsorship and their impact on content effectiveness. Study the prior relationship between influencer and audience, and the role of message-influencer congruence in sponsorship acceptance.
	Boerman (2020).	Although disclosure of the message increases recognition of sponsorship, it improves brand recall and intentions to engage with the message.	Consider different types of influencers, groups of followers according to their parasocial interaction with the influencer, and attitudinal dimensions of persuasion (not only cognitive).
	Lou et al. (2019).	Sponsored messages shared by influencers have higher engagement, involvement, positive feelings and lower negative feelings than other types of sponsored messages on social networks.	Analyse the source of social media advertisements and disclosure types, in addition to understanding the effect of the post's originality.
	Pöyry et al. (2019).	Authenticity and attractiveness positively affect the attitudes and intentions of the audience. Influencers influence purchase intentions more than celebrities, just as sponsored content has less effect than non-sponsored ones.	Understand the characteristics that influence the audience, their changes in perception when the influencer begins to appear in mass media, or when they begin to be treated as celebrities. Likewise, study the effectiveness and understanding of the message.
	Schouten et al. (2019).	Consumers trust and identify with influencers more than they do with celebrities. Similarity to the audience, identification of their desires, and trust in the influencer affect the effectiveness of the message.	Research different types of social media endorsement with different levels of engagement with the product. Study the moderating role of variables such as the type of influencer or product.
	Shan et al. (2019).	Congruence between the influencer and the consumer's ideal self-image leads to a successful endorsement. This relationship is mediated by parasocial interaction. In addition, the follower's evaluation of the influencer's motivations affects both consistency and the perceived benefits.	Examine the consistency between an influencer's image and other domains of consumer identification, as well as other influencer motivations.
	Trivedi and Sama (2020).	Communication strategies are more successful when choosing expert influencers versus attractive influencers, this relationship being mediated by attitudes towards the brand and brand admiration.	Study different audiences, cultures and product categories. Analyse the effects of the use of influencers on variables related to the brand such as: brand equity, brand loyalty, and brand recall.

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Topics	Related papers	Main findings	Research opportunities
<i>Credibility of influencers and their messages</i>	Jin and Phua (2014).	The number of followers affects source credibility; the eWOM valence influences the degree of involvement with the product, the intentions to buy and to do positive WOM.	Analyse relationships in context with high-involvement products, and consider creating social capital in a way more adapted to the medium (e.g. studying comments and retweets to people in the environment).
	Djafarova and Rushworth (2017).	Instagram celebrities who make positive reviews influence the shopping behaviours of young women, as they are more credible and closer than traditional celebrities.	Study variables such as brand recall, visual communication, the use of figurative language and the participation of the viewer on Instagram. Analyse the effects of source credibility and self-esteem.
	Xiao et al. (2018).	Trust, social influence, the quality of the arguments expressed and information involvement affect the credibility of the information shared on YouTube. Similarly, these perceptions of credibility influence attitudes towards videos/brands.	Check the results taking into account different types/formats of content and videos. Compare the effects, considering influencers with different levels of stardom.
	Jin et al. (2019).	Trustworthiness perception, endorsed attitudes towards the brand, feeling of social presence and envy of the source are greater when it comes to Instagram Celebrity than Traditional Celebrity.	Carry out cross-cultural studies and comparisons between platforms.
	Lou and Yuan (2019).	Information value of the content generated by influencers, as well as diverse perceptions of the audience about the influencer (trust, attractiveness and similarity), influence trust towards the message. In turn, this trust leads to greater brand awareness and increased purchase intentions.	Study variables such as knowledge of persuasion intentions, as well as compare different social platforms and cultures.
	Sokolova and Kefi (2020).	Purchase intentions towards products promoted by YouTube bloggers are enhanced when the influencer is credible and exhibits parasocial interaction. This interaction is, on the other hand, positively influenced by the homophily attitude and social attractiveness.	Compare different types of content and types of platforms with different forms of interaction. Analyse other types of attractiveness not based exclusively on image (e.g. voice, lifestyle, etc.).